

Chapter 1

Communication theory and professional practice

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Introduction to professional communication

This book is addressed to students undertaking professional studies and to professional graduates wishing to maintain their competence in communication as part of their profession. By the term *professionals* we mean people who apply academic or scientific theory or technical experience to their work. Ideally, professionals constantly upgrade their knowledge and adhere to guidelines of ethical practice.

The field of communication studies is large. Whole university programs relate to it. Communication professionals such as journalists, public-relations consultants, advertising account executives, film and television practitioners and creative writers combine theoretical tertiary studies with professional practice.

But other professions also feature communication skills. Nurses, medical practitioners, accountants, managers, engineers, lawyers, builders, teachers, IT specialists and librarians are only some of the professionals for whom this book has been prepared.

In describing the duties of professional people, employers invariably emphasise communication skills. Consider the advertisements for executive placements in weekend newspapers. Typically they ask for such qualities as:

- excellent communication and presentation skills
- the ability to liaise harmoniously with senior management and clients
- initiative
- team focus
- high-level oral, written and interpersonal skills
- the ability to lead and coordinate a team and liaise with specialists in other departments
- the ability to prepare proposals and submissions, etc.

That professional people need to be good communicators is, we hope, generally accepted. That professional communication competence is easy and natural, a skill you bring with you from high school or that can be picked up once in the job is anything but true. Newspapers frequently provide stories of failed communication in business dealings caused, for example, by faulty written instructions to staff or misunderstood email briefings. Some of these failures are matters of personality clashes and deliberate conflict, but many more stem from inadequate attention to communication skills.

Communication competence is likely to vary according to the forms of communication we use in professional life. Some professionals speak better than they write; others avoid public speech-making and seek refuge in the privacy of the written report. Some thrive on interviews, discussions and meetings; others have difficulty working in teams.

But there are other issues besides communication competence, and they relate not only to the language of professionals but also to the ethics of communication in the professional workplace.

Are there specific ways in which professionals communicate:

- with each other?
- with members of other professions?
- with non-professionals?

If so, are these differences explained by the complexity of professional practice? Or by the desire to guard professional secrets, to maintain market advantage or to mask professional uncertainties? What obligations do professionals have to their profession, their employers, their colleagues, their clients and society as a whole?

Have professionals a duty to make their messages clear to the public? If the language of a profession is difficult to understand, is this because professionals deliberately guard their secrets to draw a cloak around themselves and exclude those not in the know?

We have defined professionals as people whose work is based on the application of theory; so it is logical to ask what the place of theory is in communication studies. In this book, theory refers to the concepts or ideas that seem to explain communication effects or performance. Any study of a subject, even if it is only a matter of collecting data, involves taking up a theoretical position.

Since the scope of communication is so wide, no one theory adequately explains all communication phenomena. So we intend to select, from among many theories, those related most closely to the communication skills dealt with in this book. Nor shall we assert the complete validity of any one theory. We are critical of all theories and hope you will be too.

Specifically, we hope communication theory will help the professional:

- choose appropriate channels of communication
- narrow the communication gap between communicators and their audiences
- understand some of the reasons for cultural differences in communication
- understand why people get different meanings from the same message.

Defining communication

How do we define *communication*? Here are some definitions developed by communication analysts.

1 **Communication is the transmission of messages.**

In this definition the sender encodes a message, which may be an instruction, a request or a demand. It is sent through a medium – say a spoken statement, an email, a letter, a television or radio announcement – and it is decoded by the receiver. Note that in this definition the intention of the sender and the ‘packaging’ of the message affect the efficiency of the communication.

2 Communication is social interaction through messages.

In this definition communication is seen as behaviour that helps people relate to each other. People interact or exchange ideas and experiences to develop understandings. Parties take turns at sending and receiving. All take responsibility for reaching agreement or understanding and the result is better relationships between people.

3 Communication is the reciprocal creation of meaning in a context.

This definition emphasises meaning rather than message, reminding us that it is through language and other 'symbolic' forms that we generate meaning. In this definition we make sense of the world by relating to each other. Perhaps we begin with different meanings for the same thing and then negotiate a closer understanding. Perhaps we never agree on the meaning of a concept or idea, but we may have narrowed the gap between us. Meaning relates to *context* or the setting in which meaning is generated. So time, place, emotional atmosphere and culture – all these can affect meaning.

4 Communication is the sharing of meaning through information, ideas and feelings.

Sharing implies an intention to contribute, not merely an incidental coming together or interaction. This definition also tries to analyse the components of a communication. It says that meaning consists of:

- information (perception of facts such as the coming of rain during the day)
- ideas (concepts, opinions and attitudes such as commitment to a safe workplace)
- feelings (e.g. love, admiration, distrust, anger).

Thus symbolic forms like words and images may be accompanied by non-verbal expressions like laughter, frowning or angry outbursts of emotion, all adding to and complicating the search for meaning in a situation. Messages are submitted (or *encoded*) and absorbed by the group (or *decoded*).

So these four definitions of communication describe the process with different emphases. But merely defining communication does not guarantee effective communication. The capacity of people, groups, political parties, governments and nations to communicate and build constructive relationships is very limited indeed. Communication breaks down all the time and between all sorts of people, including those who are highly educated and highly articulate. Meanings differ from one person to another, even when they are looking at the same object, listening to the same speech or reading the same report. In fact it may be more appropriate, as we have suggested, to speak of narrowing the communication gap rather than achieving perfect communication between people.



Communication as the sharing of meaning.

How we use the word *communication*

Here are some typical uses of the words *communicate*, *communication* or *communicating*.

- 1 **Communication with the advance party has been cut off for four days. We're hoping they're safe.**

The phone lines are down, the mobiles are out of range, the advance party is stranded or captured. There is no contact. Technical transmission of the message has broken down. Transmission is responsible for a lot of failures in communication.

- 2 **I can't seem to communicate with my patient. I'm sure she's not taking the medication I prescribed last week.**

Perhaps the doctor gives her instructions too rapidly, or in highly scientific terms that the patient can't follow. Transmission is not the problem here; the message is being delivered, but the patient has no confidence in the prescription. So the patient's ideas and feelings are out of sympathy with those of the doctor. There has not been enough interrelating or exchanging of information and experiences between these two.

- 3 **There was good communication between group members, despite our different backgrounds. In three hours we had planned a new approach to the project. Everybody was ready to back it.**

Here there is a shared aim: to cooperate. Hence there is a willingness to reveal information and diminish any differences in feelings that might have been brought to the situation. So meaning is shared, and information can be conveyed confidently and respected.

- 4 **I simply can't communicate with my staff any more: nobody wants to do any work!**

Perhaps this manager's information is outdated or his ideas unworkable. But more likely his feelings of superiority or contempt are transmitted unintentionally but strongly. As a result his staff decline to share meaning with him.

- 5 **Communication between the old and the young is as bad now as it ever was.**

Here we seem to be discussing attitudes, ways of thinking, the effects of experience and the intolerance of differences: that is, ideas and feelings. If ideas and feelings are out of touch, information is distorted and meanings cannot be shared.

- 6 **Jean is a resourceful, pleasant and helpful executive, but when she writes a letter, memo or report, her style is over-formal and brusque. She just can't communicate in writing with her junior staff.**

Jean may use the channel of speech well to convey meaning, but her lack of training and practice in written communication means she conveys information, attitudes and feelings clumsily. Meaning is not shared.

Purpose in communicating

In one of our definitions of communication we divided meaning into information (perceived facts), ideas (concepts and opinions) and emotions (personal feelings). So, in communicating professionally, we communicate on multiple levels of meaning. Our information may be overlaid with opinion, prejudice or bias; our questions about facts may reflect doubts, perhaps self-doubt; our instructions to staff may convey distrust of them.

And yet an important concern for people communicating in the professional sphere is the purpose of sending messages or receiving them; that is, they focus on instructions, questions and explanations, so that they contain a minimum of complexity and a maximum of clarity. We might call this the *instrumental* approach to communication: we communicate to achieve certain outcomes.

But much of the time, we give communication cues without intending to do so. For example, in a tedious meeting or class we may yawn rather too noticeably, advertising our lack of interest non-verbally. In a casual conversation with a colleague, we may forget to ask about his or her sick relative. Here, the absence of our inquiry communicates

apathy about another's feelings. In neither case did we intend to communicate anything, but meaning could be drawn from these cues.

Purposeful communication is vital to your success. So you need to:

- be clear about your reason for communicating and take responsibility for your communication
- organise the message to achieve your purpose
- be clear about your meaning
- use the medium of communication to the best advantage
- frame the message to allow for any special features of the receiver(s) or the context in which communication occurs
- give your receiver(s) the opportunity to respond, so that you can see whether they have understood.

In professional life you have to talk, listen, write and read to get results. So most of your daily work is communication. That is why the study of communication is so important and deserves a prominent position in all professional tertiary studies.

Two models of communication

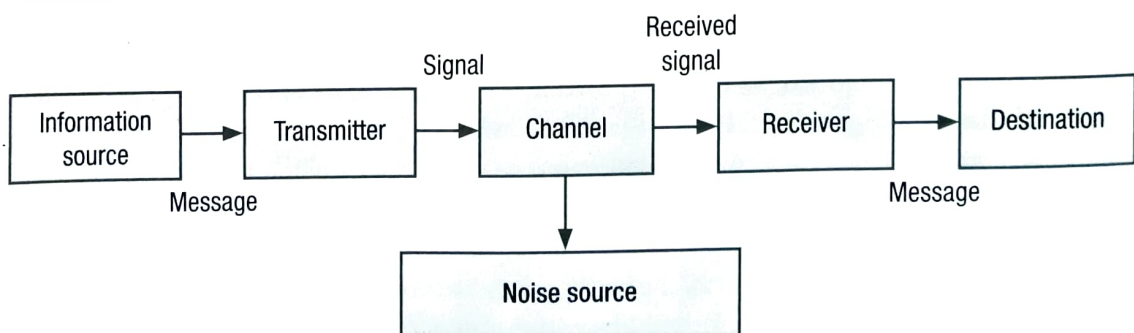
The transmission model

Two people speaking on the telephone provide a good example of the transmission model of communication.

Alex telephones Rihana. He speaks into the mouthpiece and an electrical simulation of his voice is transmitted through the cable system via a series of signals and networks. So, in terms of Exhibit 1.1 below, Alex is the information source. His telephone transmitter encodes his voice as a signal through the channel of the telephone system to the phone receiver in Rihana's office, where it is decoded and the message reaches its destination: Rihana. The arrows in Exhibit 1.1 point from the information source, Alex, to Rihana, the destination. The model seems to suggest that communication is linear and straightforward, that it moves only in one direction. Rihana, of course, will

EXHIBIT 1.1

The Shannon and Weaver model of communication



reply, and when she does, the models will be reversed; Rihana becomes the information source and Alex the destination.

This transmission model can be applied to conversation in a room, even if there are multiple sources and destinations. The voices, if they can be heard above the din, are still being transmitted, but now directly, in the atmosphere of the room, by speech, which is the channel. The signals are the voices themselves, and the receivers are the hearing and mental processes of the listeners, who are of course the destinations.

The model of transmission could also be applied to a public speech in a large hall, a lecture in a classroom, or to mediated communication on television, radio or the Internet.

The notion that ideas, facts or commands are actually conveyed as messages from one person or party to another is common. A message-centred view of communication is part of our folklore, implicit in such statements as:

- 'Am I getting through to you?'
- 'I think he's getting the message at last.'
- 'Let's see if we can push this idea at the meeting.'

The transmission model, with its emphasis on conveying a message, is also used to explain the success or failure of communication. Exhibit 1.1 includes the concept of *noise* in the channel. Nothing spoils a telephone conversation so much as a loud buzzing noise in your ear. Alex and Rihana may as well hang up and try again later. But, according to this model of communication, noise is anything that distorts the signal, and it is the signal that conveys the intended message.

This notion of human communication as transmission derives from information theory, especially the work of Shannon and Weaver, who were concerned with telecommunication theory. The main dissertation of their work is *The mathematical theory of communication* (1949), but a manageable explanation of it can be found in Colin Cherry's *On human communication: a review, a survey, and a criticism* (1978).

But is a technical system of telephone communication comparable to what happens when human beings attempt to communicate with each other? Let's consider how Shannon and Weaver's model may apply to a human communication situation.

Source and receiver

We might pursue the notion of transmission by examining another telephone conversation – between two partners in a small service-industry business. Michael telephones his business partner, Kathy. They are exchanging information, attitudes and feelings. Each takes it in turn to lead and then follow. They swap facts and figures about the business they run together. But they have different skills, different points of view, different approaches to business.

Michael wants the company to relocate to a city 1000 kilometres away, where labour is cheaper and transport better organised. Kathy knows her family will be upset at the idea and reminds Michael of the business advantages of their present location. The partners become angry with each other, with accusations of short-sightedness and selfishness. But they agree to drop the subject for the moment, until they feel calmer.

It looks as though we could consider Michael the source of the communication, with Kathy the receiver. Michael has a message for Kathy and uses a particular medium, the telephone, to let her know quickly of his exciting business idea. Kathy has been surprised by the call and is immediately alarmed by the message. Michael's information (the facts of the new plan promotion) is clear, but his ideas (the value of land in the other city, the demand for their product there) and his feelings (elation, pride) are not shared by Kathy. Throughout the conversation Kathy takes the initiative, arguing against Michael's case, giving him reasons why he is wrong. So Kathy becomes the source and Michael the receiver.

Message

Shannon and Weaver mention the message at two stages of their model: first as it relates to the source and the transmitter, and second as it links the receiver and the destination. A message has content (its basic idea), it has structure or shape, and it has a code or codes. The structure might be a narrative, an argument or an explanation. It might involve repetition, quotations or humour. The code might be language, pictures, body movements or music, or all of these.

Consider the different ways in which the same message can be treated by three different sources, for instance:

- a scientist announcing a breakthrough in AIDS research in a medical journal
- a journalist reporting the research for readers of a Sunday newspaper
- a science teacher presenting it to a Year 12 biology group.

Each will select structure and code to convey the content effectively to the particular audience.

Medium/channel

Michael uses the telephone: in fact, his mobile phone. He wants the story told quickly and confidentially. He could have sent Kathy a text message or an email but these media would lack the immediacy of the telephone call. He could hardly have dictated a letter and had it delivered to his business partner's address. Nor could he have published the news in a press release and faxed it to Kathy. But note that the choice of medium can be seen as an important part of the communication. It may put Kathy at a disadvantage, especially if she is busy in her own office, or at a meeting.

According to the transmission model, choosing the medium of communication is as important as constructing the message itself. Each medium has its own strengths and weaknesses. The telephone is fast but uses only the senses of speech and hearing. The telephone line may be bad; a couriered letter from the office may not reach Kathy if she is in another building.

Note that the term *channel* refers to the sensory base for conveying, or transmitting, messages. For example, speech and body language are the channels for the media of conversation, interviews and public addresses. Musical instrumentation, singing and

speech are the channels for opera, musical comedy and rock; speech, pictures and music are prevalent in television programs and films.

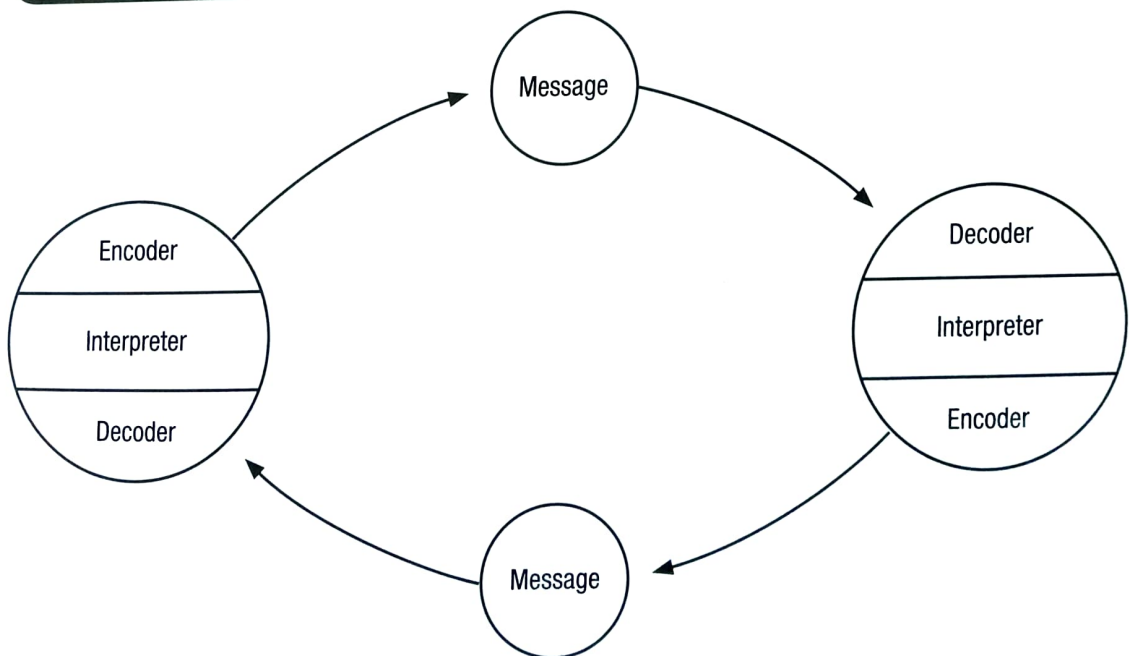
Arguably, the more channels used in a medium the richer the depth of communication achieved. In this case, speech is the only channel available to Michael.

Feedback

In the transmission model, feedback is the response to our message, the way we test the effectiveness of our communication. Not all communication involves feedback. The letter lost in the post, the telephone message given to the answering machine that failed to record, the message in a space ship lost beyond the galaxy: these all contain messages but are not communication – until they reach their destinations. For the source, it is only when there is a response that the feedback circuit is complete.

Schramm's model (Exhibit 1.2) introduces the concepts of *encoding* and *decoding*, reminding us that communication is symbolic, that it is carried out using signs and symbols: mainly language, but also non-verbal, visual and aural signs that have meaning assigned to them within a culture or between cultures. So the message, usually in words, is encoded into language and decoded by the receiver, who encodes a response which is conveyed back to the original encoder. The process is circular and continuous. There is no specific source and receiver, just a process of interactivity with two or more parties encoding messages in words or other symbols, interpreting these symbols and encoding responses. This is a useful model in that it links the notions of circularity and feedback.

EXHIBIT 1.2 Schramm's circular model of communication



Source: Schramm 1954.

In business and professional life, we speak or write to achieve results. Too often words fall on deaf ears because the message is out-of-date, boring, threatening or too technical, or because the wrong channel or medium has been chosen to convey the message. It is important that the source tests the effectiveness of his or her message. In the case of Michael and Kathy, Michael receives very strong, and negative, feedback from Kathy.

Opportunities for feedback vary a lot according to the form of communication, the social context, and the emphasis on transmission or transaction involved.

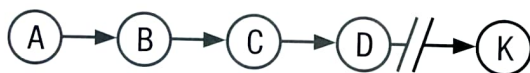
In face-to-face conversation we can immediately begin to appreciate what people think of our ideas, through their words, gestures and expressions. While watching television we may wish to contact an announcer about some remark that has annoyed us. But this contact may be delayed and our complaint not passed on. We may read in a professional journal some disparaging statement about a colleague we respect. If we wish to have the record corrected, it may take months before the next edition of the journal comes out, if ever.

At the same time, it is not easy to get people to give you feedback. Academic teachers are often anxious to measure the success of their lectures or tutorials. They may seek feedback by asking the group to write a summary of what has been said; to give their opinions on the points made; to give examples of the points made from their own experience; or to conduct a 'buzz session' in which they chat informally in pairs about what has been said and then criticise or support it.

Serial communication

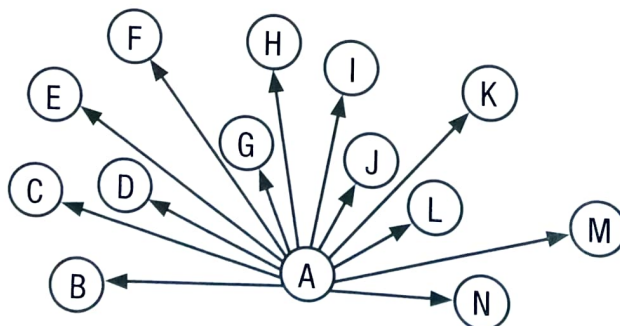
Serial communication occurs when messages flow from one party to another in a chain or series of relays. Gossip, rumour, the grapevine, or just a series of conversations can result in an item of information, true or false, circulating through an organisation like wildfire. The transmission may be:

- 1 a *single-strand chain*, like this



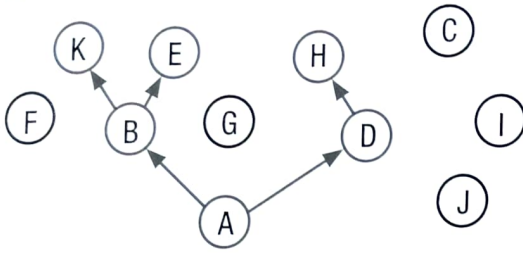
Here the message moves simply from one relay point to the next, along the chain.

- 2 a *gossip chain*, like this



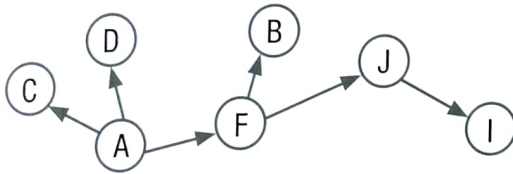
Here A is the sole source who informs others.

3 a *random chain*, like this



Here A communicates randomly to B and D, who pass the message on to others randomly.

4 a *cluster chain*, like this



Here A tells three selected persons. Perhaps one of these tells two others. Then one of these two tells one other. This last chain is probably the most common form of serial communication in a large group.

Distortions in serial communication

In everyday life much of the information we receive about people and events is second-, third- or fourth-hand, and so these messages have undergone considerable interpretation and modification before we receive them. In organisations much communication is serial. Instructions pass ‘down the line’ from general management to the ‘shop floor’. Ideas, suggestions and complaints often move from lower to higher levels.

Researchers have noted that in the serial process certain distortions of the message occur (Haney 1973):

- Details become *omitted*. This you might expect. It requires less effort to convey a simpler, less complex message. If you have fewer details to transmit, you are less likely to forget or garble the message.
- Details become *altered*. If the message seems odd or inconsistent, some relays alter it to make it more consistent.
- Details are *added*. Perhaps the relays think something has been omitted; so they insert what they think is obvious, to ‘make better sense of it’.

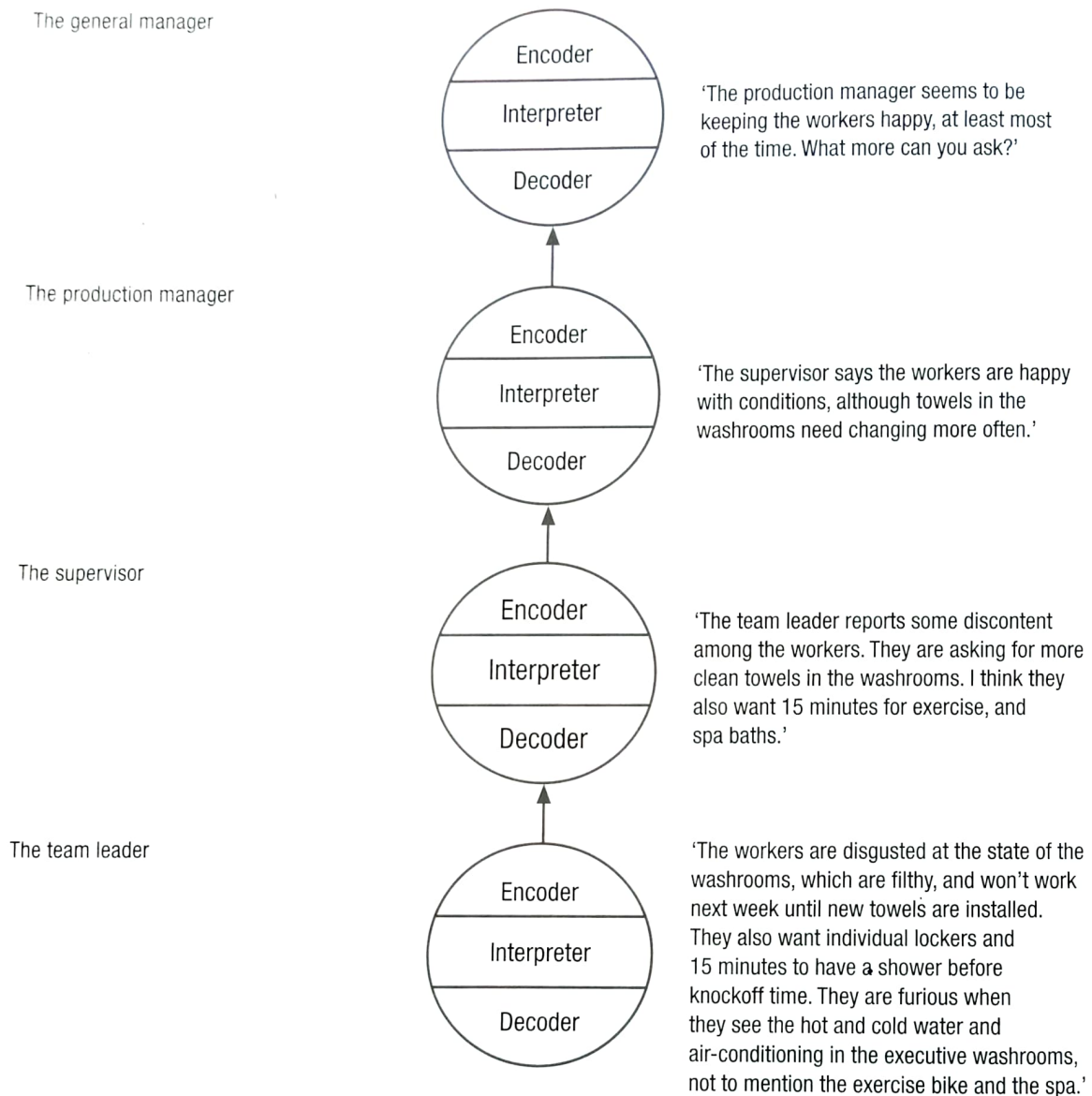
We might represent a typical complaint that moves up the chain in a manufacturing company as a vertical model in which the person at each relay point decodes the message received, interprets it according to his or her own mindset and interests, and encodes it for the next relay. The model is illustrated on the next page in Exhibit 1.3.

Summary of the transmission model

The value of the transmission model of communication lies in its emphasis on the elements in a communication process. The model reminds us:

- that sources or senders should think carefully about the effect they wish to achieve before communicating

EXHIBIT 1.3 Serial communication in the organisation



- that they should therefore structure their message carefully, using codes likely to be familiar to their receivers
- that the choice of channel or medium can be vital to the success of a communication
- that the elements of skills, attitudes, knowledge, social system and cultural awareness all play a part in the sending and receiving of messages. Overlooking the importance of any one element in the receivers especially can disrupt communication
- that feedback evaluates communication, but that feedback should be sought out as expertly as possible

- that much communication passes from one relay point to another and distortion is likely; therefore messages should be as accurate, clear and simple as possible, and the number of relay points should be minimised.

The transaction model

As we said, the transmission model of communication derives from what is known as information theory, with Shannon and Weaver's work the main source.

Critics of the transmission model say it places too much emphasis on the message and the channel of communication. More importantly, they criticise it as being 'reductionist'. They say you cannot reduce or isolate the elements of a communication situation and make any sense out of them, because communication per se is a 'big picture' that is greater than the sum of its parts.

You may be able to explain the workings of an internal combustion engine by discussing in isolation the parts of the motor and showing that when one of these breaks down the whole structure is endangered. But human communication is not mechanical. Thus, they say the use of an analogy between the mechanical and the human is misleading.

Furthermore, they argue that by placing too much emphasis on the parties to the communication and the elements within them, the model completely ignores the central issue in communication – meaning – and ignores the way meaning is created, sustained and shared between two or more parties.

The place of meaning

A favourite saying in communication studies is 'Meanings are in people, not in words'. In other words, meaning is in the *interpretation* of words, not the words themselves. Even simple terms like *good relations*, *a positive environment*, *maximum productivity* and *organisational loyalty* can mean very different things to two or three different members of a company or organisation. In the first place, people interpret meanings in context; that is, in a social situation at a certain time, between particular individuals or groups. Outside the given context, meanings may vary considerably. Furthermore, meanings do not remain constant even to each person using the words in similar situations or contexts.

For example, in an interview we may be subject to a number of different cues or indicators of meaning. If you are being interviewed for a job, you may be sensitive to:

- the interviewer's smile as you are invited to sit down (a positive cue)
- the interviewer's enthusiastic tone while reading through your letter of application and CV (a positive cue)
- the drumming of fingers as the interviewer looks up with a frown at the wall clock (a negative cue)
- the interviewer's stifled yawn while listening to your hesitant account of your recent retrenchment from another job (a negative cue).

From this composite experience of speech, gesture, movement and facial expression, you may emerge from the interview room saying to yourself, 'I don't think I'll get that job. The supervisor thought I was too inexperienced.' That is the meaning you assign to the interview. Note that much of the meaning in this interview arose from non-verbal cues and their interpretation. We analyse this means of communication more closely in Chapter 3.

Further examples of the dynamic (or constantly changing) nature of meaning are:

- a sudden change of mind for no apparent reason
- a sudden insight into a problem long after it has been unsuccessfully explained to us
- two completely different interpretations by two people of the same set of words – for example, a letter or memo to staff.

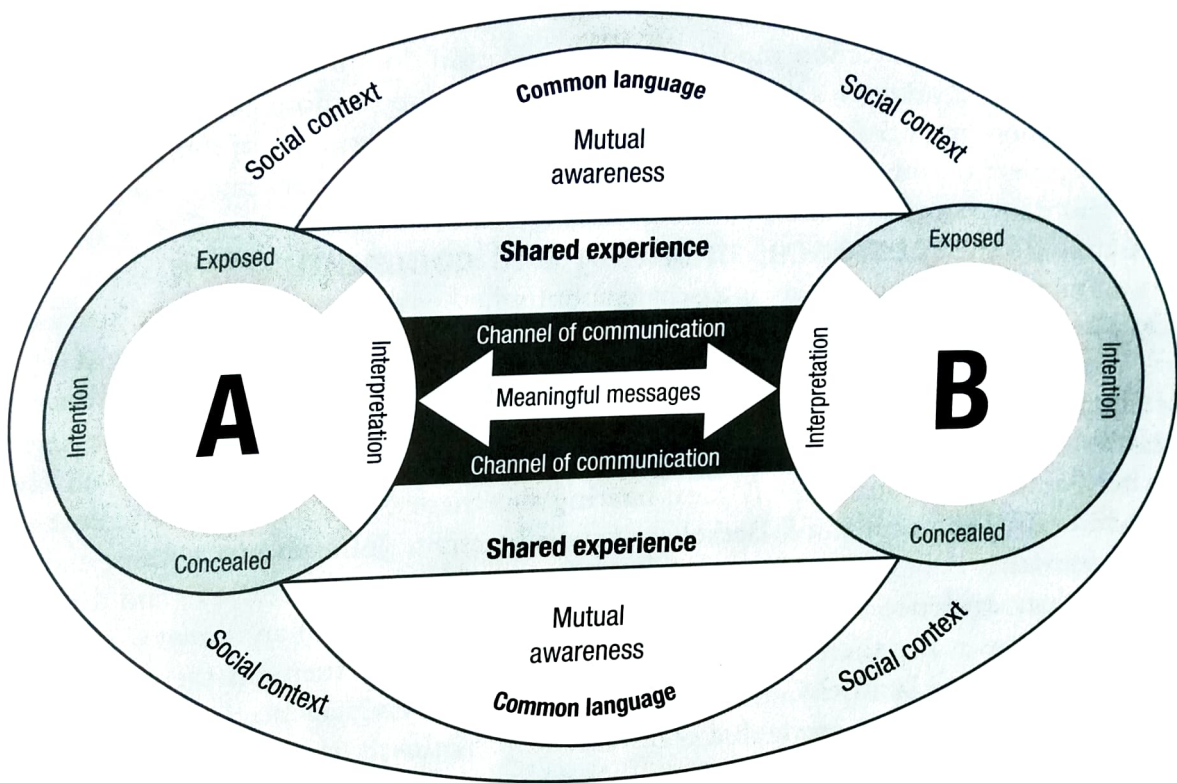
So there is no guarantee that identical inputs will lead to the same result, or that the same message will generate identical meanings for all parties, or even for a single individual, on different occasions. We are not like computers or telephone systems that can be programmed to give predictable results. Such systems are called 'closed' or 'deterministic'. Human systems are not deterministic, but rather spontaneous and discretionary. In other words, they respond not only to clear facts, agreeable attitudes and pleasant feelings, but also to moods, distractions and impulses, all of which can change moment by moment.

This is not to say that our behaviour is chaotic and completely unpredictable. People usually act fairly consistently. Most of us try to 'make sense' of our experiences. We use sign systems, mainly language, to keep us from communicating too idiosyncratically. We discuss this further in Chapter 2.

The model by Price (based on McQuail) (Exhibit 1.4) introduces the notions of *social context* and the mutual interpretation of meaningful messages in an atmosphere of *shared experience* in a *common language*. You can see how communication could fail where some or all of these ingredients are missing. A shared social context, shared experience and a common language are likely to produce better communication between strangers meeting in the city or a group working together for the first time (say as a jury) than where some or all of these are missing.

We might illustrate this concept of meaning creation by observing two solicitors in an interview. They are both women in their twenties, negotiating on behalf of their clients for an out-of-court settlement of a damages suit. The stages in their meeting might go like this.

- Stage 1** Before the meeting each has been briefed about the case, the arguments of the other side, and the claim she will try to justify.
- Stage 2** Each enters the meeting room, nervous of the other's reputation and determined not to be intimidated.
- Stage 3** They chat amiably for a few minutes, to get each other's measure. They are pleased they get on well together.

EXHIBIT 1.4**A meaning-oriented model of communication**

Source: Price 1996, p. 44, based on description in McQuail 1984.

- Stage 4** They begin to bargain, and there is tension as each tries to get the advantage.
- Stage 5** They respond to non-verbal cues, such as each other's appearance, voice and mannerisms.
- Stage 6** Both are relieved when they break for coffee. There is a joke about the weather.
- Stage 7** They become tense again when approaching the final point of the settlement.
- Stage 8** When agreement is reached and each feels her client will be pleased, they relax together with some colleagues over drinks at the bar.

During this interview each lawyer has been constructing her own *meaning* of the situation. The meanings change as the interview proceeds. Perhaps the setting or environment is the central point. The room itself generates feelings and meanings, with its austere lines and abstract postmodernist wall hangings. For each, the meanings of *negotiate*, *conflict*, *compromise*, *satisfactory settlement* and *victory* all develop and change as each stage of the discussion is passed.

Most of all, the relationship between the two people changes subtly throughout the discussion. It may harden into settled dislike and mutual suspicion, or, as we suggested, soften into camaraderie.

Therefore, the transaction model of communication does not see communication as flowing from a source to a receiver and back. Rather, two or more parties respond to a phenomenon or to the environment and bring to it their own set of interpretations. They negotiate meanings and are themselves changed by the experience.

Individual experience, meaning and communication

In communication theory there is a debate about whether the world 'out there' is objectively real or whether we create the world through our consciousness, subjectively.

The extreme version of subjectivism would claim, for instance, that a chair that we see by the window exists only if we believe it does. The philosopher George Berkeley (1685–1753) claimed that objects exist only in the imagination of the observer. The writer Samuel Johnson (1709–84), on hearing this theory, gave a chair a kick, hurt his toe, and said 'I refute it thus!' Berkeley was a subjectivist. Johnson was a realist and an empiricist: that is, one who believes that facts are independent of theories and that one can produce evidence from the factual world to prove a point of argument.

Are things really there if we don't perceive or measure them? Is there thunder if there is no-one to hear it? Can ideas exist if there is no language to describe them?

It might be easier to argue that concepts like *patriotism*, *betrayal*, *friendship* or *greed* can only be constructed in language. But we're pretty sure that Uluru, the Panama Canal and the Tower of London are out there whether you and I have had daily contact with them or not.

A more moderate and sustainable comment would be to ask what our favourite chair means to each of us: what kind of a chair it is; how well built it is; how stylish it is; and what memories and emotions, if any, it triggers in us when we look at it or sit in it. To these questions there would be a diversity of answers, and hence a variety of meanings of *chair*. Whether you are a subjectivist, a realist or an empiricist, you do, to an extent, construct your own reality; that is, give meanings to facts and events, which are different from those given to them by other people.

The personal construction of reality

This is what we mean by the *personal construction* of reality, and perhaps that is why people have so many different opinions about films, television programs, football codes (and players), and even chairs.

Constructivists say we give meanings to objects, people and ideas according to our cognitive systems; that is, our systems of mental processing. The meanings we give are based on our experiences and conditioning. These meanings in turn determine our communication (Griffin 2003, pp. 115–31).

Does this personal construction of reality produce great gaps of understanding between people? Can't we even agree that two plus two equals four? Or that water

freezes at zero degrees Celsius at sea level? These two propositions may be difficult to deny, but think about the following statements overheard on the train:

- 'The 10.45 bus is late again! It's now 10.50.'
- 'Gee, that HR manager is arrogant!'

Is five minutes late today, always late? What is arrogance? Is your arrogance my firmness of purpose?

Let's pursue this idea of individual experience. How do we experience the world around us? We do so through our sensory nerve endings. Objects in our world stand out because of their shape, colour, size, sound and smell.

Try 'looking' at an object in front of you now. Say it is the window frame of the room and it is five metres away. Are your eyes just a camera which records this sight? Apparently not. In fact, light waves are reflected off the window frame and impinge on the retina of your eye. Visual nerves send electrical impulses through the sensory apparatus to the cortex. These are recorded and decoded by the brain.

So in one sense we are aware of our nerves, not of objects. The eyes are not a camera; our experience of the world is indirect. It is as though we were sitting deep within a cave and had a friend at the cave's mouth using a mobile telephone to report to us the state of the weather outside.

The surprising thing is that we do not merely receive all this information. We unconsciously select the bits we need and ignore those not needed. If it were not so, our lives would be a miserable, frightening chaos.

For example, if you were sitting listening to a lecture, you would be conscious not only of the lecturer's voice and the content of the lecture, but also of the heat in the room, the buzz of whispered conversation around you, the pressure of your clothes on your body, and the tightness of your new shoes – all in equal degree! How much, then, of the lecturer's main points would you hear and remember?

The social construction of reality

It is not surprising that, with all this information around, we have different experiences from each other, and therefore our communication about our experience is different. What is not clear is whether these differences in perception are caused by innate psychological qualities or by what is called social conditioning. In other words, is there a social construction of reality?

In their book *The social construction of reality* (1975), Berger and Luckmann assert that we construct our world through experience and especially through language. They say we depend on relations within a group for our understanding of reality and that this reality changes when our group relations change. Knowledge can be rather unstable because it depends on how groups perceive 'facts', more than on any objective reality outside of human experience.

For example, you might claim to be a poor person because you have little money, no job and you don't own a house or car. Someone from a developing country might

say you cannot be poor because you are wearing shoes and do not seem to be hungry. Poverty, then, is defined in terms of the social group in which you experience reality; so reality differs for members of different groups (Berger and Luckmann 1975, p. 56).

Frames of reference

Whether individual or social, we seem to construct our own meanings for what we see, hear, touch or smell. Our *mental set* or *frame of reference* may be personal or social, or both. Individuals are so complex it would probably be fruitless trying to decide which is stronger.

For the communication theorist and practitioner, it is imperative to assume that there could be a gap in the construction of meanings between us, even about the simplest of facts or opinions.

So, we need to take precautions when we are communicating to ensure that, despite our differences, we can share meaning.

Leeper and the three pictures

An experiment by Robert W. Leeper (1935), referred to in many psychology texts, is rather a convincing example of the observer's frame of reference in interpreting meaning.

Leeper arranged for three sketches to be drawn (Exhibit 1.5). Picture (A) was of a young woman. Picture (B) was of an old woman. Picture (C) combined the features of the two and was considered an ambiguous picture.

To one group of students he showed only picture (A) and to another group only picture (B). Then both groups were shown picture (C).

You may be surprised to learn that no-one in either group thought picture (C) ambiguous. Those who had seen picture (A), the young woman, thought that picture (C) was of a young woman. Those who had seen picture (B), the old woman, thought picture (C) was of an old woman.

EXHIBIT 1.5 An exercise in perception (Leeper 1935)



(A)



(B)



(C)

It is too late for you to experience this experiment yourself, but try it on some other people, say two groups of four friends or colleagues. See if your results agree with those of Leeper.

What inference can we draw from this special case? Not, we suspect, that all old people would see picture (C) as that of an old woman and all young people would see it as that of a young woman. In fact, the groups seemed consistent in deriving their mental set from the picture viewed immediately before.

We all have mental sets. They might be personal, social or cultural. Think of a workplace scenario. We expect the accountant to be more concerned about the cost of a new suite of offices in the firm; the architect to be more concerned with its beauty and functionality; the publicity officer with its ability to impress visitors, and so on.

What is interesting in Leeper's pictures is the process of selection involved. For example, none of his test subjects saw picture (C) merely as that of a female person: they all saw it as either an old or a young woman.

Leeper was content to argue that we select perceptions and use them to give structure and meaning to our world, but that our worlds differ from one another. It is not difficult to understand how people's reports of the same incident, such as a fire or car smash, can vary so much (Leeper 1935, pp. 3–40).

What is the point of all this? The experiment conducted by Leeper shows that mental sets can distort communication. If we are communicating in writing, through speech or by mass media, then we must be aware of the fragility of the communicating process. Later chapters, on written and spoken communication, have this fragility as their theme.

That is why *purposefulness* in communicating is so important.

Summary of the two models

The two approaches to communication developed so far are:

- 1 the *transmission model*, which sees communication as the transfer of messages from a source to a receiver, using a channel and medium
- 2 the *transaction model*, which sees communication as the creation or negotiation of meaning in two or more parties responding to their environment and each other.

Note that these models are attempts to explain normal behaviour; they are not developed theories of communication. They can only have value for us if they sketch the likely course of a communication event.

Both these models have value and both have weaknesses.

The transmission model uses mechanistic terms like *source*, *receiver*, *feedback* and *noise*, and it assumes that information moves in a linear way from A to B. This model has value in helping us to think carefully about how we might construct a message to deliver to particular people in various ways. But mechanistic terms can be applied to human communication only as analogies or metaphors. Human communication is not mechanical, closed or predictable. You may ensure that your message allows for feed-

back, but you cannot be sure of the exact content of the feedback, or of its meaning. There is no way of ensuring that the message received is the same as the message sent.

The transaction model also concentrates on meaning. It may be useful in analysing the complexities of conversations, interviews, negotiations or large meetings. This model has value in helping us to check that we have shared our intended meaning with others. It may be less helpful in explaining how ideas are disseminated in a society or culture, how voters change their minds about candidates, or how some books become best-sellers in spite of critical reviews.

Dimensions of communication

We have looked at forms of communication, and at theories and models of the communication process. We have emphasised two main ways of thinking about communication: as transmission and as transaction. In discussing these models, we have referred incidentally to the dimensions or scale in which communication is implemented and studied. These dimensions are:

- intrapersonal communication
- interpersonal communication
- group communication
- public communication
- intercultural communication
- mediated communication.

Intrapersonal communication

Intrapersonal communication refers to communication within the self. Not merely thinking, but thinking about what we are communicating to others, listening to ourselves and monitoring our success or failure in the process of communicating with others. Such communication is difficult to discuss because it is so personal. The best way to understand it is to reflect on your own use of it. Do you debate with yourself, change your mind having thought a problem through, use your memory to bring up instances that would help you make a decision on a pressing problem? Do you listen to yourself speaking to others and criticise your presentation, perhaps changing its content and structure? If communication is the sharing of meaning, you need to be aware of your own meaning first. Of course, intrapersonal communication can easily be externalised since people often talk to themselves, write themselves notes, and so on. We take up this discussion of intrapersonal communication in Chapter 6.

Interpersonal communication

Interpersonal communication involves communicating with one or more people, perhaps to inform or be informed by them, to persuade or entertain, or merely to become

acquainted and develop a sociable relationship. Establishing close or amiable relations with others, understanding their communication style and revealing your own to them are qualities of a good communicator. Most successful professionals have skills in interpersonal communication. They may use these skills to persuade, but sharing information, ideas and feelings interpersonally is probably the most important skill to develop.

We think of interpersonal communication as possible only with close contact, but many people relate to each other only in writing and may never meet. Executives and team members who correspond globally by telephone or email are still communicating interpersonally.

Can interpersonal competence, as it is called, be learned, or is it fixed by our temperament and personality? This book suggests that awareness of ourselves and others in action can increase our success in this field. We take up the discussion in Chapter 6.

Group communication

In social and work groups of five people or more, you work with others, establish common solutions to problems, reconcile differences or engage in conflict. The emphasis in group communication is on cooperation, tolerance and the willingness to sacrifice a bit of our power and influence to further the common good and achieve outcomes. Conflict is inevitable in group communication, but it should lead positively to shared outcomes, not bullying. Like interpersonal communication, group communication usually involves people being present in the same place together. But group communication is also practised by telephone and by email, through videoconferencing and in chat rooms on the Internet. So it can also be, in a sense, mediated communication. Group communication is the subject of Chapter 7.

Public communication

Most of us feel afraid of speaking in public. The skill to communicate information, ideas and feelings – that is, to inform, influence, persuade or entertain a large group of people in a face-to-face setting – depends on adaptation of personality, cultivation of confidence and authority, and the projection of sincerity. In the end, sharing meaning is still the aim. Some people dread being required to speak to an audience, but most professionals can expect to speak in public numerous times in their careers. Chapter 9 presents some mental approaches and techniques for overcoming stage fright and planning effective presentations.

Intercultural communication

Intercultural communication involves learning about other cultures and customs. To achieve intercultural competence, you must understand new ways of thinking and behaving.

Intercultural communication refers not only to international communication but also to relations between different social, age or specialist groups within one society or one workplace. Communication, as the sharing of meaning, necessitates understanding that culture to a large extent dictates:

- customs and general behaviour
- the kind of information people think can be communicated
- the ideas they uphold
- the feelings they have and will or will not express.

Australia is viewed by some as a highly successful multicultural society, but this success depends on awareness of cultural differences and the need to tolerate and reconcile them. Chapter 4 examines some of the complexities of this subject.

Mediated communication

We can define *media* as vehicles for channels. When we speak, our voice is the channel, the air waves the medium and the auditory nerve the receiving mechanism. In writing, letters, email or text messages are the medium, and the written or spoken language becomes the channel. We encode our ideas onto paper or screen, and they are decoded by the receiver. This process can occur at the interpersonal level or the mass-communication level. Writing is as important as speech for the communicator, and, because it is more permanent, it can cause more trouble when it is inaccurate, ill-conceived or badly researched.

The writing of letters, faxes or emails one-to-one by business people or other professionals is classified as interpersonal communication. The term mediated communication also includes technological means of communication that are highly individual and interactive, like the computer, the Internet, the mobile telephone or video-conferencing facilities. The Internet, it is argued, gives the viewer, or listener, the power to become the broadcaster, and gives the reader the power to become the publisher.

The term *mass media* refers to books, newspapers, magazines, cinema, television and radio. In the professional world, the mass media impinge on policy decisions every day. The professional person needs to be aware of the power of the media and have some training in communicating effectively with the media in order to represent the interests of his or her organisation or profession, if it is under attack.

Letters, special features, press releases and public announcements may need to be framed by non-media professionals in a way that is clear to print-media specialists. Many professionals are called on to speak in interviews or public forums on radio or television on behalf of their profession or employing organisation. Chapters 8 and 9 deal with some of these techniques.

Discussion questions and exercises

- 1 Which forms of communication are most important in your profession? Give some examples and situations in which communication competence is important for you as a student or as a professional.
- 2 Discuss one recent case involving professional life in which poor communication has had serious results.
- 3 Test the claim that 'meanings are in people, not in words'. Ask members of your group to write down and then compare notes on brief definitions of the following:
 - company loyalty
 - whistleblowers
 - professional integrity
 - environmental damage
 - tariff protection.
- 4 On separate sheets of paper, write one-sentence definitions of *professionalism*, *loyalty*, *quality* and *productivity*. Then, in small groups, exchange your definitions and discuss the varieties of meaning. Note the differences of perspective and emphasis.
- 5 Write a sentence containing a statement of fact, as you see it. Exchange your statement for a partner's sentence and see if you can agree on its meaning.
- 6 Communication theorist Marshall McLuhan said, 'The medium is the message' (1967, p. 15). He meant that the choice of medium can transform a message and its meaning. Discuss this idea.
- 7 If you had to give employees of a large insurance company information about a new investment scheme that benefited them all, how would you communicate? Discuss the advantages and disadvantages of each of these media:
 - a word-of-mouth in small-group briefing sessions
 - b email announcements to all staff
 - c a notice in the weekly newsletter
 - d a video, set up in the staff dining room.
- 8 'Perhaps we begin with different meanings for the same thing and then negotiate a closer understanding.' Discuss some situations in which this might happen or has happened to you.
- 9 Which of the definitions of communication given on pages 4 and 5 do you find most useful? In the discussion you might get each member of the group to advocate one of the definitions, give an example of its practice and argue for it to be seen as the best definition.

- 10 We define *feedback* as response to a message. Without it, we cannot be sure we have communicated effectively. But how do we achieve feedback? Discuss methods of seeking feedback in these situations:
- a You keep writing essays for your lecturer, and keep receiving poor marks but few comments. You would like to improve your assessments.
 - b Promotion is coming slowly to you in the firm. Despite having finished a higher degree and having won two company awards for creative designs, you remain in the same position for three years, while watching contemporaries surge ahead of you.
 - c You have inaugurated a new holiday roster in the office. You suspect some employees are pleased because they are getting equal treatment for the first time; others are displeased because for the first time they are not getting leave when they want it.
- 11 'Getting on' with people in a work or social group is probably the most difficult communication task, as it involves aspects of personality that may be difficult to allow for. Discuss problems you have encountered, especially in the context of getting other people to cooperate and complete tasks.
- 12 Do you think your family and friends are over-influenced by the mass media, or do they tend to get their opinions from interpersonal contacts?
- Name the dimensions of communication employed in the following situations:
- having a chat with friends during the class break
 - writing home to your family
 - listening to a lecturer explaining aspects of Australian mass media
 - watching television at home with friends, and talking about the program afterwards
 - being interviewed by the managing director, reading your notes before the interview, and speaking to the MD on the phone afterwards.
- 13 If writing a letter is both interpersonal and mediated communication, what about going to a public lecture given by a politician and asking him or her a question afterwards?
- 14 If you telephone in to a radio talkback show and speak to the presenter, is this interpersonal, group or public communication (or a combination of these)?
- If you are interviewing another student on camera and the interview is recorded and played back to the whole class and some visitors, what dimension(s) of communication are involved?
- 15 What are some of the sources of or reasons for good and poor interpersonal communication that is:
- a mediated (e.g. a telephone conversation)
 - b direct (e.g. a conversation in a room together)?